

The Himalayas



THE HIMALAYAS are a gigantic chain of mountains that stretch right across northern India—a distance of about 1,500 miles (2,400 km). The Himalayas contain many of the highest mountains in the world; snow and ice cover many of the peaks year round. The mountain chain separates the cool Asian lands to the north from the tropical regions of northern India. There are a wide variety of different habitats in the Himalayas: tropical forests in the foothills, rhododendron and bamboo forests and grassy meadows higher up, and bleak tundra areas below the high peaks.

Only insects can survive at the high altitudes of the mountain peaks. They feed on plant spores, pollen, and other insects, which are swept up from the Indian plains by the strong winds. Most animals live farther down the slopes in the forests and meadows. The mountain animals have thick fur and large lungs to help them survive the cold, wind, and thin air. Many animals move down to the snow-free lower slopes and valleys in winter, while others hibernate instead.



Blood pheasant
(*Ithaginis cruentus*)
Length: up to 19 in (48 cm)

Red stripes

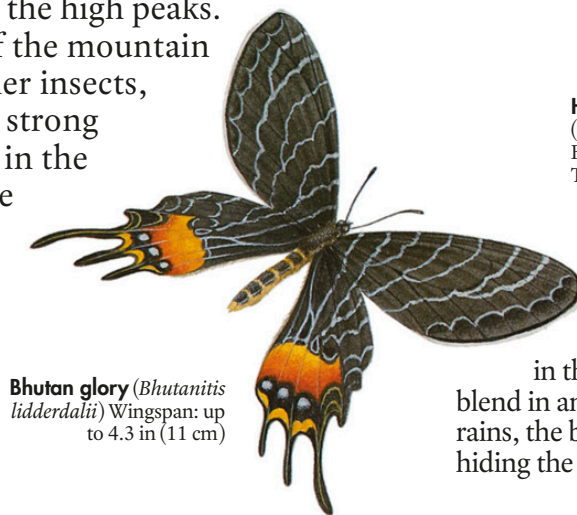
The blood pheasant is named after the bright red stripes on the male's feathers, which help him to attract a female for mating. The female bird has brown feathers, which help to camouflage her while she sits on her eggs. Blood pheasants make their nests in grass-lined gaps between large boulders. They eat pine shoots, mosses, ferns, and lichens.

Huge horns

The male Siberian ibex has huge horns, which he uses in spectacular "head-butting" contests to fight rival males. The ibex leaps around on the rocky crags where it is safe from most enemies. Its thick coat helps it survive the cold, but it also migrates to the lower slopes in winter.



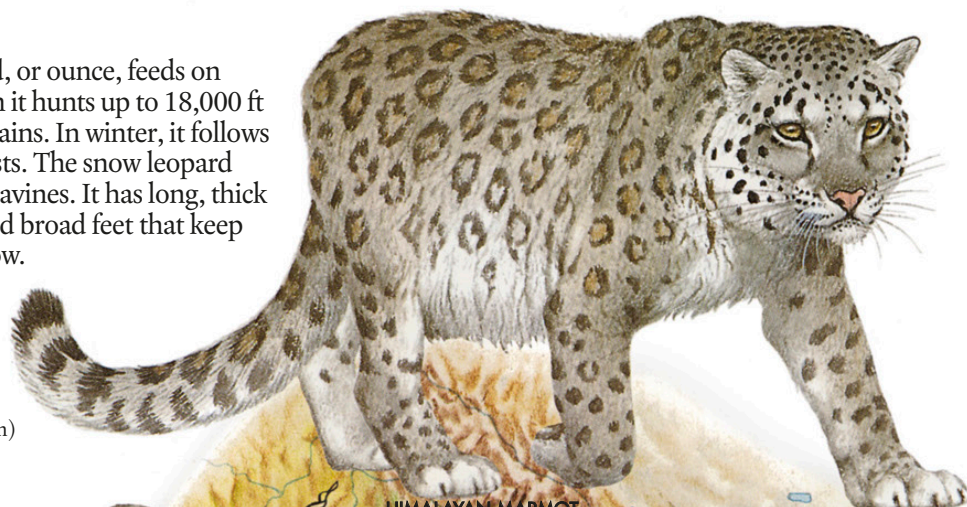
Siberian ibex
(*Capra sibirica*)
Height at shoulder:
up to 3 ft 5 in (1 m)



Bhutan glory (*Bhutanitis lidderdalii*) Wingspan: up to 4.3 in (11 cm)

High hunter

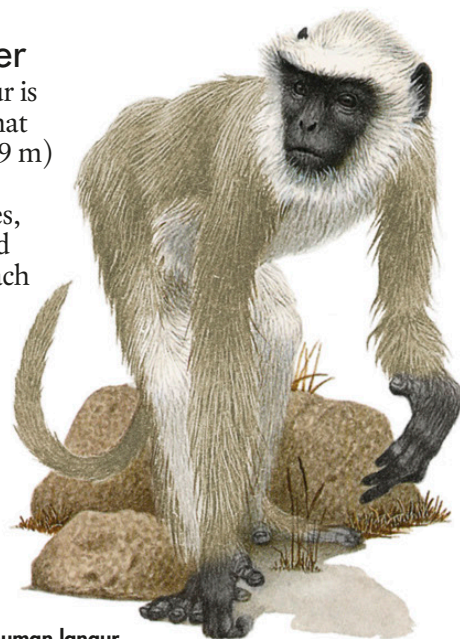
The powerful snow leopard, or ounce, feeds on wild sheep and goats, which it hunts up to 18,000 ft (5,500 m) up in the mountains. In winter, it follows its prey down into the forests. The snow leopard can make huge leaps over ravines. It has long, thick fur to help it keep warm and broad feet that keep it from sinking into the snow.



Snow leopard
(*Panthera uncia*)
Body length: up to
4 ft 1 in (1.25 m)
Tail: up to 3 ft 5 in (1 m)

Graceful leaper

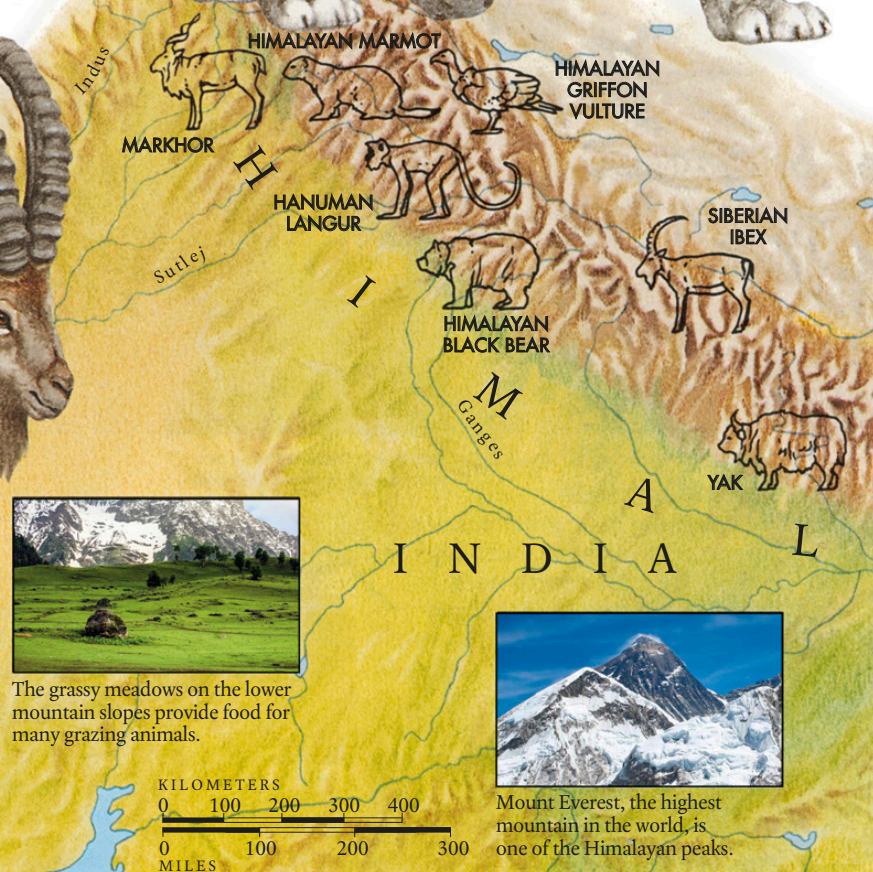
The Hanuman langur is a graceful monkey that can leap up to 30 ft (9 m) through the trees. It feeds on young leaves, fruit, and flowers and has a complex stomach and ridged teeth to help it digest its tough food. Named after Hanuman, the Hindu monkey god, it is a sacred animal in India.



Hanuman langur
(*Semnopithecus entellus*)
Body length: up to 2 ft 7 in (78 cm)
Tail: up to 3 ft 8 in (1.1 m)

Hidden colors

The Bhutan glory flies at altitudes of 5,000–9,000 ft (1,500–2,700 m) in the Himalayan forests. Its dark wings blend in among the shade of the trees. When it rains, the butterfly rests with its wings folded, hiding the bright colors on its hindwings.



The grassy meadows on the lower mountain slopes provide food for many grazing animals.



Mount Everest, the highest mountain in the world, is one of the Himalayan peaks.

KILOMETERS
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MILES
0 100 200 300